

BANDEEP SINGH



8 Wilting Will IC-814 Hijacked, 1999

On December 24, 1999, five masked terrorists seized in mid-air the controls of an Indian Airlines flight (IC-814) from Kathmandu to Delhi with 178 passengers and 11 crew members on board. Six days later, the government capitulated to the Pakistani hijackers' demand for the release of three top terrorists lodged in the Indian jails. "Every time you make major concessions, you are preparing the ground for several more in the future," INDIA TODAY quoted J&K governor G.C. Saxena in January 2000.

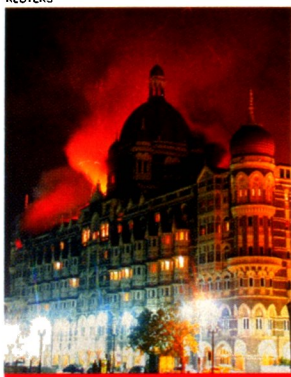
9 House Attacked Parliament, 2001

December 13, 2001, saw an audacious terror attack on Parliament which the intelligence agencies had no clue about. "The attack on Parliament was reality television at its horrific best, September 11 and the World Trade Centre translated into Indian idiom," said INDIA TODAY in December 2001. The elaborate terror plot was hatched for eight months by the terror organisation in Pakistan and their local modules in Delhi and Kashmir.

10 India's 9/11 Mumbai Attacked, 2008

The 59-hour-long televised tableau of terror that unfolded in Mumbai on November 26 and numbed the nation was the new benchmark for terror as well as for the in-built sloth in India's intelligence and security set-ups. The audacious attack, simultaneously carried out at 11 places in India's financial capital, by a group of 10 armed terrorists, came from the Arabian Sea. "Indian citizens are condemned to be the permanent victims of jihad and a political class which has no sense of the nation," said INDIA TODAY in its December 2008 issue. **by Ramesh Vinayak**

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national security triumphs

Moments when India basked in the glory of smart moves

1 The Iron Hand Despite the Cold War, Indira Gandhi engaged in back-to-back summit diplomacy. The 1983 NAM summit castigated both the US and USSR.

2 The Wall Falls After more than 30 years of hostility and a near war in 1987, Rajiv Gandhi's visit to China in December 1988 broke the ice on the Sino-Indian border dispute.

3 Looking East P.V. Narasimha Rao's Look East policy of 1992 helped India focus on the region that was near in culture and geography, but distant in diplomacy, with little political and economic engagement.

4 Flexing Muscle In a scientific and strategic triumph, India conducted two series of nuclear tests, code-named Shakti, at Pokharan in the Thar desert of Rajasthan in May 1998.

5 Turning Point In 2000, US President William Jefferson Clinton's visit to India transformed the US world view of South Asia and for India, it brought a de-hypenation of the US policy on India and Pakistan.

6 The New Great Game In 2001, India launched a diplomatic initiative in Afghanistan aimed at winning hearts and minds. It launched relief and reconstruction work across the country much to the chagrin of Pakistan and the Taliban.

7 National Interest India said no to sending troops to Iraq in 2003. This was despite intense US pressure and veiled threats that strategic ties could be jeopardised.

8 Disaster Diplomacy In the face of its own death toll of 10,000 in the December 2004 tsunami, India's proactive role in relief and reconstruction efforts in Sri Lanka, Indonesia and Maldives won it global accolades.

9 Lethal Weapon In April 2007, the launch of Agni III, an intermediate-range ballistic missile, provided India with the ability to hit targets in Pakistan and China. The missile provided India a lethal nuclear deterrent.

10 The Cliffhanger The Indo-US nuclear deal in 2008 ended India's nuclear apartheid, cemented bilateral ties and became the biggest foreign policy trophy for the UPA Government.

by Saurabh Shukla